

Handle Success Like You Handle Failure: Overcoming the Fear of Failure, featuring Greg Hiebert

Greg Hiebert, Leadership Coach & Managing Partner

Pat Summitt spoke these words about the fear of failure: “Too many people opt out and never discover their own abilities because they fear failure. They don't understand commitment. When you learn to keep fighting in the face of potential failure, it gives you a larger skillset to do what you want to do.”

A necessary part of reframing failure is to recognize that we have to make failure our friend. And it's been put in our path to help us grow and learn. Pat Summitt said, “You can't have continued success without experiencing failure.”

Consider this: as an inventor, Thomas Edison made 9000 unsuccessful attempts at inventing the light bulb. And when a reporter asked, “How did it feel to fail 9000 times,” Edison replied, “Why would I feel like a failure? And why would I ever give up? I now know definitely over 9000 ways an electric light bulb will not work. Success is almost in my grasp.”

Certainly, failure is painful and causes emotional turmoil, as well as inflicts agonizing pains of guilt, remorse, and regret. However, for those who have known true failure and have bounced back from it, they understand that failure in life is necessary for success. In fact, if we studied highly successful people, we would learn that most of them failed numerous times before understanding the right patterns and formulas for success.

Conrad Hilton, the historical and famous hotel magnate, went bankrupt numerous times before succeeding. Walt Disney did the same. It's no surprise that Pat had an excellent analogy about failure and winning basketball games. Pat said, “You don't win basketball games on first shots. You win them on second and third and fourth shots, and you can't achieve multiple success on first shots either. Follow-up is the secret to continued success in anything.”

If you try to go through life without failing at anything, then you're not really living a life at all. Taking risks and falling down flat on our faces is part of life. It makes us into who we are. Pat Summitt understood the value of failure. How can you use failure to improve your game?